

CHICAGO SPORTS

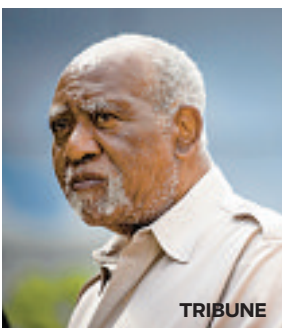
ECHOES OF RYNO

Amid a playoff push, emulating Ryne Sandberg — and 1984 vibes — might be best way Cubs like Nico Hoerner, right, and fans can honor the legend, writes columnist Paul Sullivan.



CHICAGOLAND

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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

US envoy heads to Israel

Trip for talks comes as toll in Gaza continues to climb

By Wafaa Shurafa and Sammy Magdy
Associated Press

DEIR AL-BALAH, Gaza Strip — Israeli strikes and gunfire in the Gaza Strip killed at least 48 Palestinians overnight and into Wednesday, most of them among crowds seeking food, health officials said. U.S. envoy Steve Witkoff headed to Israel for talks

after ceasefire negotiations with Hamas appeared to have stalled last week. Israel has come under mounting international pressure in recent days as its ongoing military offensive and blockade have led to the “worst-case scenario of famine” in the coastal territory of some 2 million Palestinians, according to the leading international authority on hunger crises. Witkoff, who has led the Trump administration’s effort to wind down the nearly 22-month war and release hostages taken in Hamas’ Oct. 7 attack that sparked the conflict, will arrive Thursday in Israel for

talks on the situation in Gaza. A U.S. official confirmed the visit, speaking on condition of anonymity to discuss plans not yet made public. Of those killed in the latest violence, more than 30 were seeking humanitarian aid, according to hospitals that received the bodies and treated dozens of wounded people. Another seven Palestinians, including a child, died of malnutrition-related causes, according to the Gaza Health Ministry.

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Schools feeling budget crunch

CPS will offer fewer food options, custodial services this fall amid fiscal woes

By Kate Perez
Chicago Tribune

Amid a \$734 million budget deficit and with a little less than a month before it needs to be filled, Chicago Public Schools announced reduced services for the 2025-26 school year, including hot meals for students and custodial operations. The reductions come as CPS has held multiple community meetings and Board of Education discussions attempting to find solutions to the budget shortfall. The budget is required by law to be balanced by Aug. 28. The school year begins Aug. 18. Come the first day of school, students are likely to see reductions in areas beyond the classroom. CPS will operate with changes in reduced lunch staffing, likely to result in simplified menus, fewer hot meal options, or cold meals being served on certain days, according to an update sent out to parents from CPS Chief Operating Officer Charles Mayfield. The district’s current after-school meal program, which offers free meals at select schools, will no longer offer hot dinners and instead provide packaged snacks. However, it will continue to offer its free breakfast and lunch program, which provides meals that it said meet federal nutritional standards. CPS provides over 260,000 free meals to students yearly. The after-school supper program varies each year depending

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BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A ‘weight lifted’

Jimmy Soto, right, hugs his cousin and co-defendant, David Ayala, after a court hearing for their certificates of innocence on Wednesday, while celebrating with family, supporters and their attorneys at the Leighton Criminal Court Building in Chicago. Released in 2023, Soto and Ayala earned the unfortunate distinction of becoming the longest-serving wrongfully convicted people in Illinois after 42 years behind bars. Soto said having the certificate will allow him to travel without restrictions, and both men said it would help them to move on with their lives. Chicagoland, Page 4

Taking more mental notes

Chicago pianist ‘grateful’ to be playing music again after life-changing brain surgery

By Tess Kenny
Chicago Tribune

A hospital bed in Florida isn’t Mark Burnell’s typical performance venue. But this spring, with an electric keyboard in his lap and 14 holes drilled into his skull, the longtime Chicago musician struck up a melody on the old ivories. The tune was a time-honored, and fitting, classic from “The Wizard of Oz”: the Scarecrow’s seminal hit, “If I Only Had a Brain.” Standing bedside, Burnell’s wife, Anne, sang along. “I would not be just a nothin’ my head all full of stuffin’, my heart all full of pain,” she crooned. “And perhaps I’ll deserve you, and be even worthy of you, if I only had a brain.” Burnell, a pianist and singer who has gigged, directed and taught across Chicago since 1989, underwent brain surgery in April at a Mayo Clinic campus in Florida, after a year and a half spent managing monthly seizures. The procedure used



Pianist Mark Burnell, who underwent brain surgery in April, rehearses in his Chicago home with drummer Bob Rummage on Tuesday. ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

innovative brain mapping techniques and even mid-surgery performances by Burnell himself to see through. But ultimately, the treatment proved successful at tempering Burnell’s epilepsy, he and his surgical team say. Now, a few months into recovery, the Burnells on Thursday night will be staging their first large public concert since Burnell’s surgery.

Headed into the concert at the Gateway Lounge in Chicago’s Copernicus Center in Jefferson Park, Burnell says he’s eager to perform, especially with the newfound freedom that surgery has given him. “I’m on the road to healing,” Burnell said, sitting down for an interview Monday

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Officials seek input into how auto insurance rates are set

By Jeremy Gorner
Chicago Tribune

Just weeks after Gov. JB Pritzker called for action following State Farm’s 27.2% rate hike for homeowners insurance, some state lawmakers and officials said they are renewing efforts to address the steady rise in auto insurance rates. Curbing the cost of auto insurance has been the subject of several legislative proposals in the last couple of years, but those measures have yet to go anywhere. The Illinois secretary of state’s office, which has unsuccessfully promoted a measure that would eliminate factors such as credit scores and advanced age from being used as metrics to set car insurance rates, is set to launch a campaign to highlight why it thinks employing those factors is unfair to consumers. “This, to me, is an economic justice issue. People are struggling to pay their bills. People are required to have car insurance, and it’s becoming unaffordable for folks to have it,” Secretary of State Alexi Giannoulias said. “So if the purpose of auto insurance is to protect the eight and a half million Illinois motorists, it only makes sense that

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